

The below section is strictly a point of view based on the facts of the case, feel free to disagree or counter the opinion (in fact, that can be a rather interesting conversation) and write to us on the same.

Case 1: Mars orbiter crash

The first case that we mentioned was the crash of the \$100 million mars climate orbiter (MCO) due to a simple confusion of units.

The MCO as you will recall had set orbit at 57 kms from the surface of mars instead of the intended much higher 145 kms and was destroyed due to the increased atmospheric friction.



Good documentation could've averted this crisis

This was the result of engineers using imperial units instead of standard ones.

The question here is why did the engineers choose to use different metrics for the calculation? Turns out they were US-based engineers who were usually using imperial units for measurement.

Would this still have happened if the requirement document clearly mentioned which units to follow in the first phase itself? Would it have been avoided if the requirements thus captured were converted into a set of test cases that specifically checked for this condition? A simple practice of having the requirements of the project clearly and objectively mentioned